



THE CARAVAN AMBUSH

A ONE-SHOT ENCOUNTER FOR 6 LEVEL 6 ADVENTURERS

Theme: Desert road / supply delivery mission with cinematic, fast-paced ambush.

Tone: Gritty survival meets absurd game-show energy (CloudCutter's Challenge #3).

Encounter Level: Hard (for 6x level-6 PCs)

Setting: The dusty Arventian trade road between the portal ruins of Veth'ar and the crimson mesas of Durnfell.



BACKGROUND

After completing their last portal recovery task, the party has been hired by **CloudCutter**, the red dragon host of "*CloudCutter's Challenge*", to safely deliver a **wagon of enchanted supplies** to the *Festival of Masks*—a Halloween-style celebration where adventuring teams gather for revelry and contests of skill.

The catch?

CloudCutter "forgot" to mention that several rival teams were tipped off to the delivery, eager to intercept the cargo and claim the dragon's favor themselves.



ADVENTURE HOOK

"Six wagons of fireworks, wine, and wands—what could possibly go wrong?"

— CloudCutter, moments before vanishing in a puff of smoke.

The party's job is to escort a single caravan wagon through a narrow stretch of road flanked by low dunes and scrubland.

Halfway to the festival grounds, they're ambushed by rival bounty hunters and feral wolves drawn by the scent of blood and food.



ENCOUNTER SETUP

Environment	Conditions	Visibility
Sandy trail between cliffs and scrub	Windy, dry heat	Bright sunlight

- **Terrain:** Uneven, with scattered boulders (half cover) and a wagon (full cover).
- **Wagon:** 40 HP, AC 12. Flammable — if struck by fire, begins burning (5 fire damage/round).
- **Supplies:** The party loses bonus festival reputation points if the cargo burns or is stolen.



PACING GUIDE

Round	Events
Start	3 × Scouts + 2 × Wolves attack from the dunes.
Round 3	2 more Scouts arrive on a ridge (reinforcements).
Round 5	A final wave of 1 Scout and 1 Wolf enters from behind.
Objective: Survive 6 rounds and protect the cargo until the storm passes or foes retreat.	



ENEMIES



SCOUT (CR 1)

Medium humanoid (any race), any alignment

Armor Class: 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 16 (3d8 + 3)

Speed: 30 ft

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

Skills: Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5

Senses: passive Perception 15

Languages: Common plus one

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

Multiattack. The scout makes two attacks with its shortsword or longbow.

Shortsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing.

Longbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 150/600 ft, one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing.

Keen Eye. The scout has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks relying on sight.



WOLF (CR 1/4)

Medium beast, unaligned

Armor Class: 13 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed: 40 ft

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	15 (+2)	12 (+1)	3 (–4)	12 (+1)	6 (–2)

Skills: Perception +3, Stealth +4

Senses: passive Perception 13

Challenge: 1/4 (50 XP)

Pack Tactics. The wolf has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of its allies is within 5 ft of the creature and not incapacitated.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. *Hit:* 7 (2d4 + 2) piercing. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Keen Hearing and Smell. The wolf has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks relying on hearing or smell.



ENVIRONMENTAL RULES

Fire Spread:

If a burning arrow, Fire Bolt, or torch strikes flammable materials (wagon, crates, grass), the fire spreads 5 ft per round. A creature can use an action to extinguish a 5-ft square.

High Winds:

Ranged attacks beyond normal range are made with disadvantage.

Difficult Terrain:

Moving off-road (into sand dunes) costs double

movement.

Visibility Shift (Round 6):

A sand squall begins — ranged attacks have disadvantage, and Perception checks take –5 until combat ends.



REWARDS

- **600 XP** divided among the party.
- **Festival Entry Invitation** from CloudCutter (VIP table at the Halloween Masquerade).
- **1d4+1 random enchanted trinkets** among the wagon's cargo (DM's choice or roll).
- Reputation bonus if supplies arrive undamaged.
- If they fail → CloudCutter mockingly dubs them "*The Ashen Couriers.*"



OUTCOME OPTIONS

Victory:

The party earns CloudCutter's approval and gains early access to the Festival of Masks, where rival adventuring teams await.

Partial Success:

The wagon burns or supplies are lost, but the players survive. CloudCutter offers sarcastic praise and a new "bonus round."

Failure:

They're overwhelmed; the caravan is looted, and they awaken in the desert—rescued by another adventuring team (hook into next session).



SCALING NOTES

- **Easier:** Remove one wolf and one scout from the first wave.
- **Harder:** Add an additional CR 2 **Veteran Mercenary** in Round 5.
- **Cinematic Variant:** Have CloudCutter appear briefly mid-fight to commentate, providing inspiration or chaos.



DM NOTES

- Emphasize **speed and chaos**: every round feels cinematic and tight.
- Keep **in-character commentary** from CloudCutter fun and loud.
- Fire + wind = tension and consequences.
- End on a triumphant or comedic note leading into the Halloween festival.